The Model Minority Stereotype and Help-Seeking in Asian American College Students

Bradley Allen, Melissa R. Witkow

Introduction

- In the United States, the model minority stereotype (MMS) has been used to compare other minoritized groups to Asian Americans, who are stereotyped as intrinsically intelligent, hardworking and technically proficient (Lee & Joo, 2005; Taylor & Stern, 1997).
- Prior research has explored differences between Asian American emerging adults who have internalized the MMS as a stereotype of innate intelligence versus a stereotype of hard work (Witkow et al., 2024).
- Studies have found that instrumental help-seeking (i.e., seeking the minimum amount of help necessary to solve a problem on one's own) and executive help-seeking (i.e., seeking help to avoid effort) are associated with growth and fixed mindsets, respectively (Cutumisu & Lou, 2020).
- Self-esteem has been found to decrease when an individual encounters setbacks that challenge their ability or increase when presented with an opportunity to remediate setbacks (Nussbaum & Dweck, 2008).
- The goal of the current study is two-fold:
  - First, examine the mediational role of instrumental help-seeking on the relationship between the MMS internalized as a stereotype of hard work and self-esteem, and;
  - Second, examine the mediational role of executive help-seeking on the relationship between the MMS internalized as a stereotype of innate intelligence and self-esteem.

Methods

Participants

- Asian American college students (*N = 226*) recruited using a Prolific Panel during the spring of 2024.
- Participants were 64% female, 30.5% male, 4.9% non-binary, and 0.4% other, with an average age of 20.8 years (*SD = 1.92*).

Measures

- Modified M-Achievement subscale of the IM-4 (Yoo et al., 2010, 2015)
  - *Internalized stereotype of hard work* was measured on a 5-point scale (1 = *Strongly disagree*, 5 = *Strongly* agree) with 5 items (e.g., In comparison to other racial minorities, Asian Americans are harder workers).
  - *Internalized stereotype of innate intelligence* was measured on a 5-point scale (1 = *Strongly disagree*, 5 = *Strongly agree*) with 5 items (e.g., In comparison to other racial minorities, Asian Americans are naturally smarter).
- Help-seeking (Karabenick, 2003)
  - *Instrumental help-seeking* was measured on a 5-point scale (1 = *Strongly disagree*, 5 = *Strongly agree*) with 2 items (e.g. If I were having trouble understanding the material in one of my classes I would ask someone who could help me understand the general idea).
  - *Executive help-seeking* was measured on a 5-point scale (1 = *Strongly disagree*, 5 = *Strongly agree*) with 2 items (e.g., Getting help in class would be a way of avoiding doing some of the work).
- 10-item Rosenberg Self-Esteem Scale (Rosenberg, 1965)
  - *Self-esteem* was measured on a 5-point scale (1 = *Strongly disagree*, 5 = *Strongly agree*) with 10 items (e.g., I feel that I have a number of good qualities).

Tables & Figures

Table 1

Associations Between the Model Minority Stereotype Subscales and Instrumental Help Seeking and Executive Help Seeking.

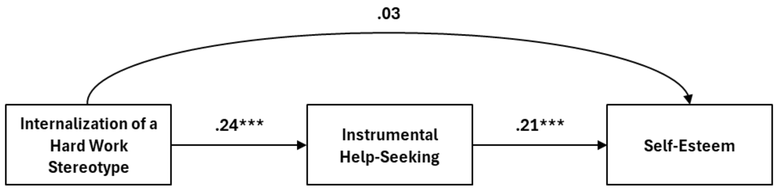
Variable	B	$SE\ B$	β	t	
Instrumental help seeking					
Constant	2.63	.25		10.56	***
HW	.26	.10	.25	2.87	**
II	-.04	.10	-.04	-.42	
R^2				.05	
$F(2,223)$				6.14	**
Executive help seeking					
Constant	1.65	.27		6.01	***
HW	-.07	.10	-.06	-.65	
II	.36	.11	.29	3.38	***
R^2				.07	
$F(2,223)$				8.06	***

Note. HW refers to the internalization of hard work stereotype and II refers to the internalization of an innate intelligence. $SE =$ standard error.

*** p < .05, ** p < .01, *** p < .001**

Figure 1

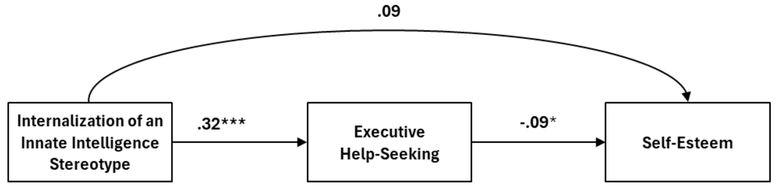
Model Demonstrating a Significant Positive Indirect Effect of Internalization of a Hard Work Stereotype on Self-Esteem Through Instrumental Help-Seeking



Note. Shown are unstandardized regression coefficients.
$*p < .05.$ $**p < .01.$ $***p < .001.$

Figure 2

Model Demonstrating a Marginally Significant Negative Indirect Effect of Internalization of an Innate Intelligence Stereotype on Self-Esteem Through Executive Help-Seeking



Note. Shown are unstandardized regression coefficients.
$*p < .05.$ $**p < .01.$ $***p < .001.$

Results

Multiple regression revealed:

- Internalization of the MMS as a stereotype of hard work but not internalization of the MMS as a stereotype of innate intelligence was found to significantly predict instrumental help seeking (Table 1).
- Internalization of the MMS as a stereotype of innate intelligence but not internalization of the MMS as a stereotype of hard work was found to significantly predict executive help seeking (Table 1).

Mediational analysis revealed:

- A significant *positive* indirect effect, indicating that instrumental help-seeking mediated the relationship between an internalized stereotype of hard work and self-esteem (Figure 1).
- A marginally significant *negative* indirect effect, indicating that executive help-seeking marginally mediated the relationship between an internalized stereotype of innate intelligence and self-esteem (Figure 2).

Discussion

Conclusions

- Multiple regression analysis suggests that internalizing a stereotype of hard work leads to behaviors that are likely to lead to *more* learning. Similarly, internalizing a stereotype of innate intelligence leads to behaviors that are likely to lead to *less* learning.
- Mediational analysis suggests that internalizing a stereotype of hard work increases self-esteem when the student engages in instrumental help-seeking. Similarly, internalizing a stereotype of innate intelligence reduces self-esteem when the student engages in executive help-seeking.
- These findings add to the current literature on internalization of the MMS by American college students by demonstrating that internalization of a hard work stereotype versus a stereotype of innate intelligence differentially predicts help-seeking, the result of which is higher or lower self-esteem.

Limitations

- This study was part of a larger survey, which limited the number of variables. For example, personality and locus of control could change the nature of the relationship between internalization of the MMS and help-seeking.

Future directions

- Examine these associations by replacing self-esteem with test scores (e.g., midterm versus final test scores) over a semester. Research has shown that students who engage in instrumental help-seeking compared to executive help-seeking see an increase in test scores from midterms to finals (Karabenick, 2003). It is expected that internalization of a stereotype of hard work from the MMS will result in higher end of semester grades and an internalized a stereotype of innate intelligence will result in lower end of semester grades..
- Examine these associations and frequency of academic resource engagement (i.e. attending professor office hours or engaging with peer tutoring). Researchers has found that students with low-self esteem are more likely to be disengaged in academic settings (Acosta-Gonzaga, 2023). It is expected that internalization of a stereotype of innate intelligence will result in less academic engagement when mediated by executive help-seeking.